

Westhampton Solar/Energy Subcommittee Minutes
December 18, 2025

Teri Anderson called the meeting to order at 5:30pm

Committee Members Present: Scott Stanton, Susan Bronstein, Teri Anderson, Jen Milikowski (arrived at 5:47pm).

Others Present: Dan Abrahamson, Energy Manager; Andreas Schmid, Solect Energy

Review Revised Elementary School Solar Costs and Battery System Specifications/Vendor:

Andreas summarized:

- Former battery provider Socomec pricing increased several times due to tariffs and their pricing did not include all the components for a microgrid battery system making their proposal too expensive for the MVP grant funds appropriated to the town.
- Solect Energy team vetted several other vendors (Renon, Fortress, Generac) and settled on Generac, a US based company in business since 1959 and now making battery systems. They offer the technical, engineering and operational support needed for the project and pricing that can work under the grant budget assuming no upgraded transformer. They are a reputable and reliable company. This would be Solect's first project with Generac.
- The Generac battery system is larger capacity at 258kWh vs 226kWh for Socomec allowing the battery system to operate for longer periods of time when the grid is not functioning.
- Similar Lithium Iron Phosphate battery type which is stable chemistry.
- The battery system would be derated to 75kW to avoid the need to upgrade the existing transformer, saving \$40,000.
- The Generac proposal includes all components needed for a microgrid.
- The school's current peak demand is 40kW so 75kW would power the entire school for 6.5-7 hours using the battery system only if the power is out and the sun is not shining.
- The design assumes 50% reserve in the battery backup system to ensure battery supply when power goes out.
- Will connect to the existing Kohler generator at the school.
- If the Town increases the electric load demand in the future, calculations would be needed to determine if the existing transformer could handle the load and, if not, what size generator would be needed. Any increase to use additional battery system capacity would need a new Interconnection Agreement from Eversource which is possible to do.
- In the pro forma, the estimated battery revenue is based on added generating capacity from selling excess energy back to the grid rather than cost savings.
- Dan stated existing boilers at the school have another 5 years to end of life. Inquired about a transformer upgrade to accommodate future upgrades. Andreas said it would be hard to design/estimate an appropriate transformer size now without knowing future upgrades anticipated at the school. He recommends waiting which may also decrease the backlog in transformer supply through the utilities.
- Batteries to be refreshed in year 11 of the life of the system. Teri asked about a second refresh in year 22 because we estimated a second refresh for the Socomec batteries.

Andreas said refresh costs are included in pro forma, but year 22 refresh costs are unknown. Assume 3% inflation, but battery costs may go down by then due to increased market demand or newer technologies by that time.

- Batteries have a 10-year warranty with operational/maintenance annual servicing by Solect.
- Andreas can't answer all of our questions on the battery specifications but Solect Battery Engineer will provide that information along with warranty specs soon.
- Both Generac and Socomec battery cells are manufactured in China. Comparable quality and similar technology.
- AOBC in pro forma replaces net metering for excess generation – electric bill credits. The system won't over produce a lot, but some. Future load upgrades (e.g. fast car charging stations) may use up any excess - would need a demand profile study. The system will also receive MA SMART system payments. Managing the battery to produce energy back to the grid is not part of the pro forma. Town would need to partner with a company that specializes in managing these systems like IceTech or C-Power. This would be a revenue sharing arrangement on the system excess generation.
- Yes, the isolation stepdown transformer mentioned in spec notes is included in the pricing and allows the system to behave like a regional electric system (meaning it can operate independently from the grid) and meets all safety compliance requirements.
- The battery will still be located 15ft from the school near the generator. Solect will create a site plan as soon as the Town authorizes this system change.
- Scott asked about trade-offs made by Generac compared to Socomec. Generac is discounting some of the tariff costs in order to offer competitive pricing to win Solect's business.
- The Town won't be eligible for the Federal tax credit payment because foreign manufacturer of concern requirement goes into effect 1/1/26. We won't meet that deadline.

Scott Stanton motioned to recommend to Selectboard to accept the project with the new battery system and project costs proposed by Solect with Generac as the battery vendor and to proceed with submission of the Interconnection Agreement application to Eversource under the existing Letter of Intent between Solect and the Town, seconded by Teri Anderson.

Roll call vote: Susan Bronstein-yes, Jennifer Milikowski-yes, Scott Stanton-yes, Teri Anderson-yes. Voted unanimously.

This recommendation will go to Selectboard at their 12/29/25 meeting.

Other Business:

Jen mentioned it would be important to expedite the delivery and installation of the solar panels on the Public Safety Building. Solect will get the crew out there next week. The goal is to complete by the end of the year.

Motion by Susan Bronstein, second by Scott Stanton to adjourn the meeting at 6:46, unanimous.

Minutes Prepared and Submitted by Teri Anderson